In India, too, cultural traditions continue to recall the ancient trade routes. For instance, in the state of Orissa, the festival of Kartik Purnima still celebrates the day when Sadhaba merchants set sail for South-East Asia. People light lamps before sunrise and set them afloat on small paper boats in rivers or in the sea. The festival is held in early November when the monsoon winds reverse. At the same time, in the town of Cuttack, a large fair takes place—called 'Bali-Yatra' (literally meaning 'the voyage to Bali'), scholars feel it marks the departure of merchant fleets for the island of Bali.[10] These festivals echo a culture that celebrated its entrepreneurs and risk-takers.

Further south, the seventh-century stone temple of Mahabalipuram still stands on the shore as if waiting for merchant fleets to come home. The town, 60 km south of modern Chennai, was a thriving port under the Pallava dynasty from the seventh to the ninth century AD. According to local legend, the existing temple complex was only one of seven such temple complexes that once existed. It was said that the sea swallowed up the other six temples as well as numerous palaces, bazaars and other grand buildings. Local fishermen had tales of how their nets would often get tangled in underwater structures. Serious historians, however, used to dismiss these stories as mere myth.

On 26 December 2006, a massive earthquake devastated the Indonesian province of Aceh and triggered a tsunami across the Indian Ocean. The event is estimated to have killed 230,000 people. The tsunami struck India's south-eastern coast as well. However, before the waves crashed in, the sea withdrew a couple of kilometres. The residents of Mahabalipuram reported seeing a number of large stone structures rising from the seabed. Then the sea returned and covered them up again. Since then, divers have confirmed that there are a large number of man-made structures out in the sea although they have not yet been systematically mapped. The tsunami also shifted the sands along the shore and uncovered a number of other structures, including a large stone lion.[11] Archaeologists also found the foundations of a brick temple from the Sangam period that may have been destroyed by a tsunami